



rehabilitation breaks to not wanting to be away from family during the holiday season and other contractual nitty-gritty. *Sportstar* has learned that a few players had been insisting on signing a three-year agreement with the teams, but in vain.

Four of the eight withdrawals were from the SRBT outfit. India defender Udit, whose services were acquired by the Tigers for a record Rs 32 lakh, said, "Many international players have decided not to play after the auction. It would be wonderful if the foreigners could join us in full strength ahead of the next edition. They can help us develop our game better. I am sure things will change with the two new teams coming in next season," she said.

Having not lost any of its foreign players (yet), Odisha seemingly has the strongest squad on paper. But a lot of its momentum would hinge on the formidable Yibbi Jansen, the highest goalscorer and gold medallist at Paris 2024. The presence of Janneke Schopman in the backroom rounds the squad up. There won't be many who would be more acquainted with the nub of Indian hockey than

the Dutch boss. She even managed to pick up the core of the junior Indian team she had guided to a first-ever Asia Cup in 2023.

"There's a good mix of experience and youth, and that is why we happen to be the favourite. But we have to understand now there is pressure to perform, and we have to live up to the expectations. Seniors like Grace di (Deep Grace Ekka) are returning, although she has retired from the international circuit (January 2024), and that makes me excited for the days ahead," Ishika said.

Incidentally, there were a number of prominent faces who did not get even as much as a sniff from the auction table. This saw the Hockey India League Governing Committee jump into action mid-auction to reduce the base price of unsold athletes of the Indian senior and junior women's teams to Rs 2 lakh. The decision, Hockey India said, had come in response to a collective appeal from the players.

Among the players who were eventually roped in, there was a consensus regarding the salary not being enough. "Yes, the money and

**Dutch drag-flicker Yibbi Jansen,** Paris Olympics gold medallist and top scorer, was signed by Odisha Warriors for Rs 29 lakh, becoming the second most expensive player. GETTY IMAGES

budget are not that great as of now, but I am sure this league is going to touch new highs pretty soon," Pipers' Sangita Kumari had said despite being among the top five of the most expensive bids placed at the auction. She had been snapped up for Rs 22 lakh.

HIL did miss a fair deal by not onboarding a private broadcast partner ahead of the auction, but eventually, the multilingual telecast rights were sold to the Sony Sports Network on December 13. In its efforts to popularise the sport across the country, Hockey India has also decided to forego the revenue it would have generated from ticket sales by making entry across the men's and women's competitions free for all.

Whether the move indeed tempts Ranchi denizens to fill the 5,000 seats at the arena remains to be seen.